

Family **Timaliidae****Babblers**

Length 10–35 cm (4–14 in)

Species 55



Found in Africa, Asia, and Australia, most babblers are heavy-bodied birds with a stout bill. They are highly gregarious and maintain contact mainly through quiet calls. Most species are sedentary; only a few migrate. Many babblers are insectivores but some also eat fruit and many are omnivores. The ground feeders rummage in leaf litter, while the more arboreal species find invertebrates on leaves and bark. Nesting habits vary: a number of species build domed nests low down or at ground level; however, song-babblers build an open nest in a bush or tree. Some species even have a cooperative breeding system—birds that are not breeding help the new parents with incubating the eggs and feeding the chicks. Both the incubation and the nestling periods take 13–16 days. Young birds may remain with a group of adults for a year

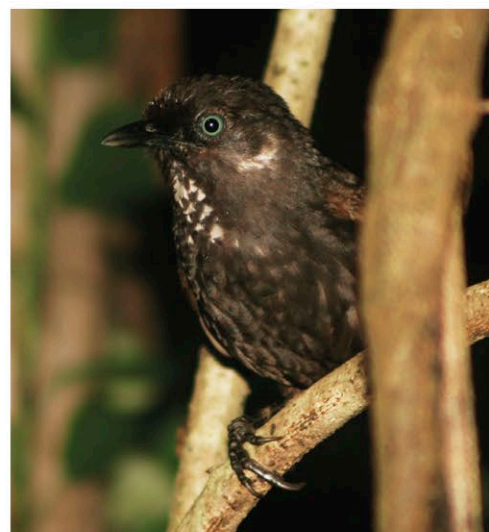
or more. Scimitar babblers, mostly found in the Himalayas, have distinctive curved bills and striking head patterns and join mixed feeding flocks.



long, downward-curving bill

LARGE SCIMITAR BABBLER

Widespread in evergreen forest and bamboo at heights of up to 7,600 ft (2,300 m), *Pomatorhinus hypoleucos* is found on the forest floor, often digging into the soil with its long bill. It is 11 in (28 cm) long, has a high-pitched, mellow hoot, and is found from Pakistan to south China and Southeast Asia.

**NONGGANG BABBLER**

Discovered on limestone highlands straddling the China-Vietnam border, and formally described in 2008, the Nonggang babbler (*Stachyris nonggangensis*), like many of its allies, flies only short distances and prefers to walk—when it searches for invertebrate prey among leaf litter. It forms flocks in winter, but associates in pairs when breeding.

Family **Leiothrichidae****Laughingthrushes**

Length 4–14 in (10–35 cm)

Species 133



Most of these are jungle birds, difficult to see in dense rainforest but, as their names imply, easier to locate by their loud laughing or babbling calls. Others live in more open habitats. They have short wings and a weak flight, but quite long tails and strong legs, indicating a terrestrial lifestyle. A short, stout bill deals with a varied diet of seeds, fruits, and often substantial insects, such as large-bodied moths. They have plain or well-patterned plumages, including rich and varied colors, with distinct patches on the wing. Laughingthrushes have a variety of head markings, including dark caps or masks and bold eyerings. Some have short,

wide crests that can be raised in a fan. While some species are common and familiar, others in remote areas are little known but appear to be endangered through habitat loss.



orange breast

red bill

RED-BILLED LEOITHRIX

A very popular caged bird, thanks to its melodious, warbling song and attractive plumage, *Leiothrix lutea* is found from the Himalayas to south China and Southeast Asia. The female's throat and breast are paler than the male's and she lacks his red coloration in the wings.

This bird is 6 in (15 cm) long and forages in bamboo and scrub with other babblers.



black cap
blackish bill

long tail

rufous back

rufous underparts

long tail with bands

RED-TAILED LAUGHINGTHRUSH

There are about 133 species of laughingthrush, of which *Garrulax milnei* is found in south China and Southeast Asia, in scrub, grass, and second-growth forest above 3,300 ft (1,000 m). It is 10 in (25 cm) long and has red wings and a red upper side to its tail; the underside is black.



red tail with black underside

reddish wings

RUFOUS SIBIA

Also called the black-capped sibia, *Heterophasia capistrata* is a Himalayan bird, found from northern Pakistan eastward to southern China. It is 8½ in (21 cm) long and favors deciduous forest, especially oak woodland, but is also seen in coniferous forest. It drinks sweet sap oozing from holes in tree bark, and is also known to feed on insects.

